

"We have doubled our customer base every single year since we started"



Shashank Mehrotra,
GM and business head, BigRock

BigRock has recently joined hands with Neustar, a provider of real-time information and analysis to the Internet, telecommunications, technology, retail, media and advertising industries, to promote .biz as the preferred domain for small businesses in India. As part of this initiative, BigRock and Neustar have outlined an aggressive outreach campaign that includes a series of new television commercials (TVCs), extensive digital outreach, and a complete online presence for businesses. The online presence will include a .biz domain name, Web hosting, hosted email for the .biz domain name and Google Adwords coupons worth Rs 2500, all of which are integrated with an easy-to-use interactive website builder priced at Rs 199. **Diksha P Gupta** from *Open Source For You* spoke to **Shashank Mehrotra, GM and business head, BigRock**, about this initiative and the company's growth in India. Excerpts...

Q: How big is the domain name business in India these days?

Let me first give you the numbers in terms of the overall size of the domain name business in India. There are two types of domain names—one is gTLDs and the other is ccTLDs. When we try to calculate the size of the domain name industry, we try and ascertain the number of all the registrants (an individual who has booked a domain name) who originate from India. We use that proxy to figure out the size of the industry. There are no external agencies that independently audit this but we have a fairly sophisticated analytics team that looks at this aspect. By our estimates, there are around 3.2-3.5 million domain names in use by Indian registrants today.

Q: GoDaddy has set up its Indian arm almost a year back. How has its presence affected BigRock?

Before I specifically answer that question, let me tell you how the industry is actually laid out. This is not a new industry. Domain names have been booked in India much before BigRock started. Historically, Directi, which is the parent entity for BigRock, has been a very strong player in India with over 47 per cent of the market share for over a decade. Directi's Reseller Club, LogicBoxes and BigRock, combine to hold over 50 per cent of the market for domain name registration.

Now coming back to your question about GoDaddy... it has always been present in India, though the company has physically set up operations in India in the last year.

Because it is the largest global brand, consumers are aware of GoDaddy. What has changed is that it has started focusing on the Indian market in the last 12 months or so, but it has always been present. To specifically answer your question on how we look at it—we welcome any competition that helps in enhancing the profile of the business and enhances the industry and education levels among customers, in general. If you look at the penetration of domain names amongst Indian users, that number is still ridiculously low. As I said, we have about 3.5 million domain names. The number of domain names as a percentage of Internet users is very low, as we have anywhere between 130-140 million Internet users today. So, only around 2 per cent of the Internet-accessing population has a domain name today.

If you look at the ratio of the Internet-using population vs domain names across other markets like the US, China, Turkey, Germany, etc, those numbers are much higher. Out of 100 people who use the Internet in the US, at least 26 or 27 actively translate into domain names. Whereas, in India, that number is just 2. So, with the growth of the Internet economy and with the need to get more and more businesses online, we feel this market is only going to grow. GoDaddy being physically present here is an affirmation of this growth in some sense. We have been here, and we have done a lot of campaigns in promoting the domain names business. Their being here is an indication that they agree with us.